

| 1998 | L.N. MITTAL IS THE RICHEST INDIAN

Man of Mettle

Mittal's wealth was not only about numbers, but an empire built from scratch

If you were not an Indian, you could have easily missed him. At No. 177, he was the richest Indian worth \$1.9 billion on the *Forbes*' list of billionaires. It was the time when the Sultan of Brunei with \$58 billion topped the list and Bill Gates, worth \$36.4 billion, was the second richest man in the world. True, he was richer than the Hinduja brothers and the Ambanis, but based in London, he could have been just another trader accumulating arbitrage. Only he was not. In the world of steel, he had already attracted notice; in the world of mergers and acquisitions, he had a tenacious presence. The turnaround artist dubbed the "new Carnegie of steel" by *The Economist*, Lakshmi Niwas Mittal, had left India in 1976 with just a degree in commerce from St. Xavier's College, Kolkata, to conquer the world. While India moved from self reliance to Reliance and to liberalisation, Mittal was busy notching victories, taking over plants in Ireland, Trinidad, Germany, Kazakhstan and Mexico. INDIA TODAY

had profiled the entrepreneurial talent and the success story of this Marwari boy in April 1998 when he was virtually un-

known bar in the NRI circles. Mittal then explained the difference between opportunity in India and abroad most memorably: "I produce 17 million tonnes of steel per year, India produces 20 million tonnes". In less than 10 years since then, Mittal has emerged as the biggest steel producer in the world. So big that ArcelorMittal

is three times bigger than the No. 2. His business is now spread across 60 countries in five continents. ArcelorMittal is the leader in all major global markets, including automotive,

construction and packaging. In 2008, it produced 103 million tonnes of steel and recorded revenues of \$124 billion. He also straddles an emerging energy empire with interests in Australia, Kazakhstan, South Africa and India.

The rise has been "mittal-eoric" for sure. In 1998, he was envied by NRIs in London for his \$10-million mansion in Hampstead, London. He now lives in a home that cost him \$128 million.

The man who trailed Gates by 175 ranks in 1998 was just one rank below the Microsoft mentor at number four in 2008. Post-meltdown, he may not be the richest Indian but he is still the biggest steel maker in the world. And as he says his dream is not constrained by digits. "We are chasing scale, creating a new architecture of business." **by Shankkar Aiyar**

THE MAIN EVENT

Pokhran Nuclear Tests

The blast sites of India's latest nuclear tests at Pokhran look like innocuous craters. But if one of the bombs tested was exploded above ground, then this is what would happen: the first effect would be a flash of light so intense that people 50 km away could suffer from permanent retinal damage if they looked at it. The light is emitted by a rapidly expanding, intensely hot fireball. Those within a 3 km radius would either be incinerated or die of burns. Within seconds, a blast wave radiates out with hurricane force, crushing buildings, uprooting trees and killing all life forms in the area. As the blast reduces in intensity, a huge mushroom cloud containing radioactive material begins to drift. The fallout can give a lethal dose of radiation to people living within 50 to 100 km from the blast. *India Today, May 25, 1998*

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA www.indiatodaymag.com



FORMER PM VAJPAYEE AND OTHERS AT THE TEST SITE

ALSO

- Amartya Sen is awarded the Nobel Prize in economics
- Cellphone connections reach one-million mark
- The ambitious National Highways Development Project is implemented

Rahul Gandhi His steady stride and flamboyant speeches speak volumes about his newfound confidence.

M.S.Dhoni The captain not only gave up his rebounded poker straight hair but also picked up some chutpah in between.

Kareena Kapoor Power yoga and dieting transformed Poo whose size zero in *Tashan* set off a completely new trend.

Narendra Modi Always seen in kurtas and loose trousers, his recent sartorial choices are turning quite a few heads.

Nita Ambani Twenty-five kg less, Chanel dresses and Hermes handbags have replaced her shimmering salwar-kameez.